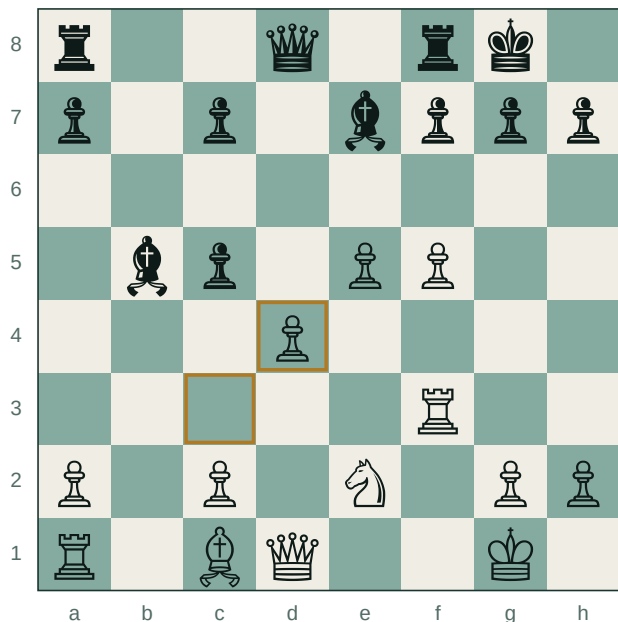


# Capture the defender: Black, move 17

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 17.cxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**17...Bxe2 18. Qxe2 Qxd4+ 19. Qe3 Qxa1**

**17...Bxe2** The bishop captures the knight on e2. From e2 it attacks queen on d1 and rook on f3. Recorded reply: **18.Qxe2**.

**18...Qxd4+** Check restricts White to 7 legal replies here. From d4 it attacks king on g1 and rook on a1. Recorded reply: **19.Qe3**.

**19...Qxa1** The queen captures the rook on a1.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 28 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

## CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +6:** the balance goes from -1 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

## CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

## WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

## HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on d1 and rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.